

How To Survive a Classification Study

By Shelley Mosley

“WE’RE HAVING a classification study next week. The job auditors should be here Monday.” These simple pronouncements can strike terror in the heart of the most even-tempered librarian. However, you can live through—and yes, actually triumph over—the most arduous study. There’s often little or no warning involved, so the time to prepare for a classification study isn’t when it’s announced. It’s right now.

City and county governments order classification studies periodically, either of their entire structure, or an individual unit. Studies serve several purposes. They analyze an organization’s structure and determine which jobs should exist and which employees should be slotted into them. Positions are upgraded, downgraded, or left unchanged.

For example, if your institution has Library Assistants I and II but other departments have classifications such as Accountant and Senior Accountant, the library assistant jobs may be renamed for consistency. Obsolete classes, such as Key punch Operator, are abolished, while new ones, such as PC Network Specialist, may be added.

Real world impact

Despite official claims that classification does not reflect compensation, it inevitably does. Studies can synchronize hierarchies in traditionally female agencies, like libraries, with those in traditionally male agencies, like fire and police departments.

Library job titles—and their job descriptions—are far from standardized. In some systems, for example, a Senior Librarian position may be earned simply by longevity; in oth-

ers, the job requires supervisory duties. Classification studies become a “meet and confer” item in unionized departments: both the process itself and the implementation of the results are negotiated.

There are several kinds of classification systems. The most common are the point factor system, in which job factors are assigned points, and the broad banding system, in which positions are sorted into a small number of categories.

Ralph Andersen and Associates (point factor); the Hay Group (point factor); Ernst and Young (broad banding); and the Mercer Group (point factor) are four of the largest management consulting firms specializing in classification and compensation systems. Both the point factor system, which this article focuses on, and broad banding require similar preparation.

Know and explain what you do

Probably the most important thing in a classification study is your ability to tell others what your job entails. Never assume everyone knows what you do. How many times have you heard, “I wish I worked in a library so I could sit around all day and read books”?

It’s vital to specify your job duties. The description “I take care of the periodicals” is ambiguous and leaves a lot to the auditor’s imagination. Instead, you could say, “I receive, process, and distribute magazines and newspapers. I track the subscriptions and notify the vendors of errors and nondeliveries.”

Positions may be evaluated through written documentation as well as interviews with the employee and supervisor. Never take job questionnaires lightly, and make sure supervisors behave similarly.

One way to know your job duties is to keep an informal log over a three- or four-week period. Some library duties are affected by circulation cycles, so a single week’s log may not accurately reflect the scope of work you do. Don’t bother logging one-time assignments unless they’re major projects that stretch out for weeks or months. Keep current and accurate organizational charts and job descriptions. Collect job descriptions from other library systems for ideas if you’re starting from scratch or if your job descriptions need a total revamping.

You should be familiar with your current classification system. Find out why you’re classified as you are and what other positions share your factors or your banding. Have someone from the human resources department explain the current process, the new process, and what factors will be evaluated (see sidebar, p. 49).

Job auditing biases

You may be audited by a human resources analyst, a team of employees trained in classification, or an outside consultant. Be wary. Auditors can be biased or misinformed. They might be convinced that since librarianship is a predominantly female profession, librarians should be classified below those in predominantly male fields. The job auditor may have just studied paramedics, who save lives, and concluded that libraries

You may only have an in-depth study once in ten years—but a decade is a long time to live with a wrong classification

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are strictly a "nonessential" or "leisure" service.

You must educate the auditor—and the rest of your organization—as to what library staff really do. This public relations effort should be ongoing and start long before an audit. Cloistering may be great for religious orders, but you need to spread the word on libraries. Network with other departments in your jurisdiction. "Out of sight, out of mind" really means "out of luck" during a classification study.

Worst foot forward

Sometimes, only a few people in a classification are chosen for an audit. They then presumably represent the class as a whole. If those staffers are unprepared and respond poorly, the results can be lethal to others.

One upper-level paraprofessional in a public library youth department, when asked by an auditor what decisions she made, blurted out, "I get to pick what colors the letters are for our displays." Had she been prepared, she would have explained her actual job duties: designing displays for the children's area, planning youth programs, and answering reference questions.

What not to say

Classification isn't an exact science; nonquantitative measures require judgment. You want the job auditor to gain a positive impression of you and your work.

You shouldn't insult or antagonize him or her, although an amazing number of people manage to do just that. Avoid the following phrases, which regularly alienate job auditors:

- "My job's so complex there's no way you could possibly understand what I do...." You don't impress auditors by insulting their intelligence.
- "I do so much you don't have time to hear everything I do, and wouldn't even if you stayed here all day...." People who say this are often trying to hide their unpreparedness.
- "My supervisor keeps that kind of information. Ask her, not me...." No one likes to pry information out of people, especially an auditor who has several other interviews after yours.
- "She makes more money than I do, but she doesn't work nearly as hard." Two people can have completely different workloads and be classified at the same level. But workload isn't a classification factor; it can be a management issue involving uneven work distribution or it can be a matter of perception. Other factors not used to determine classification include skill level, seniority, and duties voluntarily done outside of the job description.

Ten Typical Factors In a Job Classification

In a point-factor classification system, some or all of the following areas may be evaluated. You should think about how they apply to your job so you can answer fully and accurately when the time comes.

- 1 Decision-making** The scope and impact of your decisions; the amount of supervision you receive; how much authority you have; and your range of independence or autonomy.
- 2 Guidelines** The rules and regulations that affect your job. How much judgment you're allowed in their application and whether or not you're permitted to develop new guidelines.
- 3 Education** The education and training needed to perform the basic or "essential" functions of the job. Your educational attainment isn't relevant.
- 4 Experience** The experience needed to perform your job. Again, your experience isn't relevant.
- 5 Complexity** The nature of your work, how many different types of tasks are performed, and what steps or processes are involved. Organizations apply this in different ways.
- 6 Supervision** How many people you supervise. This may include contractual workers, temporary staff, volunteers, and/or interns. Lead and shift supervision and project management may count.
- 7 Resources** Everything from budgets to equipment and facilities.
- 8 Contacts** The public; vendors; departments outside the library; boards and commissions; library associations; and other libraries. The nature and frequency of these contacts are evaluated.
- 9 Working environment** Libraries are generally evaluated at the same level as standard offices.
- 10 Physical effort** The physical demands of your job. Among many other tasks, librarians push heavy book trucks, bend, stoop, stretch, reach for books on the shelves, and lift stacks of books or heavy reference volumes.

■ "Why is he classified at a higher level than I am? It's just not fair." The purpose of a job audit is to make sure you are classified at a level commensurate with your duties and level of responsibility. It doesn't aim to judge you against someone else.

■ "My boss takes all the credit for what I do." Ranting, raving, and putting down your managers wastes the job auditor's time and suggests you're a malcontent, damaging your credibility.

Terminology, tone of voice, and attitude are all important. Don't whine. Don't lie. Don't exaggerate. Watch your words. Beware of modifiers: "significant," "extensive," and "comprehensive" all mean specific things to job auditors...and they aren't necessarily what you think they are. In short, to be considered a professional, behave professionally.

Death by adverb

Don't exaggerate, but don't understate. And never apologize for what you do. A job audit is the worst time to be humble. Typical suicide phrases include "I'm just a..." or "I only...."

If you have a hard time talking about yourself—and most of us do—practice telling your friends and family about your duties. Rehearse with other staff members before audit interviews.

For example, don't say, "I only check books in and out." Instead, say, "I check materials in and out; interface with customers; resolve conflicts regarding overdue materials; and share information about our library's circulation policies with the public." "I just buy the books" could be stated as "I have the authority to allocate funds within my budget for whatever areas of the collection I deem appropriate."

Know the appeals process

Many classification studies provide the opportunity for an appeal. Sometimes this isn't widely publicized. You must find out about this before the study begins. If you ask too late, the deadline for appeals may have come and gone.

Due to the dynamic nature of organizations, classification schemes are often valid for only five to seven years. But the classification process is labor-intensive and expensive, so it's not unusual for an organization to wait ten years for an in-depth study. This is why good preparation is so important. A decade is a long time to live with the wrong classification. ■